

Kitchen card · one pot

SoulJere's Zuppa Toscana

Creamy sausage and potato soup with bacon, kale, and a blended-potato body. One pot. Five to six bowls.



House bowl. Kale still green. Potato tender. Sausage in the cream.

Yield: 5–6 bowls · About 45 minutes · Eat in 2–3 days for the kale · Cream last, no hard boil

In the pot

Item	Amount	Notes
Italian sausage	1 lb	Mild default. Hot sausage if you want heat.
Fresh bacon, chopped	6 oz / ~6 slices	Half of a 12-oz pack. 8 oz only if you want it meatier.
Yellow onion, diced	1 medium	In the bacon fat.
Fresh garlic cloves, minced	3–4	Not the jar. House lock.
Red pepper flakes	¼ tsp (½ if hot sausage)	Any brand.
Chicken cooking stock	1 carton (~32 oz / 4 cups)	Splash first to scrape fond.
Water	Only to cover potatoes	Not a swimming pool.
Russet potatoes, peeled, ½-inch half-moons	2 medium-large (1.5–1.75 lb)	High-starch russets for body.
Kale, ribs stripped, chopped	1 bunch	Add at the end so it stays green.
Heavy whipping cream	1 cup	Extra-rich toggle: 1½ cups.

Method

1. **Sausage.** Brown 1 lb Italian sausage in a 5–6 qt pot, breaking it up. Pull to a bowl. Leave the browned bits.
2. **Bacon.** 6 oz chopped fresh bacon over medium. Render until edges crisp. Keep about 2 Tbsp fat.
3. **Aromatics.** Onion in the fat until soft. Fresh garlic + flakes, 30–60 seconds. Do not burn the garlic.
4. **Fond.** Splash about ½ cup stock. Scrape. That is the flavor step. Do not flood it yet.
5. **Potatoes.** Potatoes in. Rest of the carton. Water only until the potatoes are just covered.
6. **Simmer.** 12–15 minutes, until a knife slides through.
7. **Body.** Blend 2 cups potato + broth (or stick-blend one corner). Pour back. Do this before kale and cream.
8. **Green and meat.** Kale and sausage back in. 3–5 minutes, wilted and still green.
9. **Cream.** Heat down. 1 cup cream. Do not hard-boil. Taste. Pepper if you want. Salt only if the pot is actually dull.
10. **Rest.** 5 minutes off heat. Serve. Eat this pot in 2–3 days.

Hard rules

- This is a 5–6 bowl pot so the kale stays worth eating. The old 5–6 russet stockpot lasts half a week and the greens die.
- Fresh bacon and fresh garlic are the house. Recipe pieces and jar garlic are last-resort toggles, not the card.
- Half a 12-oz bacon pack (6 oz) is the default. Half a 16-oz slab is the heavy toggle, not an obligation.
- Water only to cover the potatoes. Extra water is thinner soup, not generosity.
- Blend before kale and cream. Two cups is the measured body.
- Do not salt before you taste. Sausage, bacon, and stock are already salty.

Options and substitutions

If you want	Use this	Do not
Heat	Mild sausage + ¼ tsp flakes (default). Hot sausage + ½ tsp flakes.	Don't stack extra salt on hot sausage.
Bacon	6 oz fresh (locked). 8 oz if you want it meatier.	Don't use the pouch bits and call it the same soup.
Garlic	3–4 fresh cloves (locked).	Jar minced is flatter. Not house.
Body	Blend 2 cups potato + broth (locked). 1 cup for lighter. Off for thin broth.	Don't blend after cream.
Cream	1 cup. 1½ cups extra rich.	Don't hard-boil after it goes in.
Potato type	Russet for body (high starch).	Waxy Yukon stays chunky and thickens less.
Week-pot	If you ever scale up: kale-free base. Wilt greens in tonight's ladle only.	Don't park a giant pot of kale for six days.

Leftovers

Shallow containers. Fridge within 2 hours (1 hour if the kitchen is over 90°F). Fridge 40°F or below. Safety window 3–4 days. Kale is tired by day 3. Reheat only tonight's ladle to a boil / 165°F. Do not reheat the whole pot every night. Do not reheat in a slow cooker. Overnight on the stove is trash. Do not taste to check. Freezer 2–3 months for quality; cream may split — whisk it back on a gentle heat.

Why the blend thickens

Russet starch gelatinizes in the simmer (about 140–149°F). Blending 2 cups ruptures cells and dumps that starch into the broth. Same science as a roux, no flour. Day-two thicker soup is retrogradation — warm it, don't punish it with a rolling boil.

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